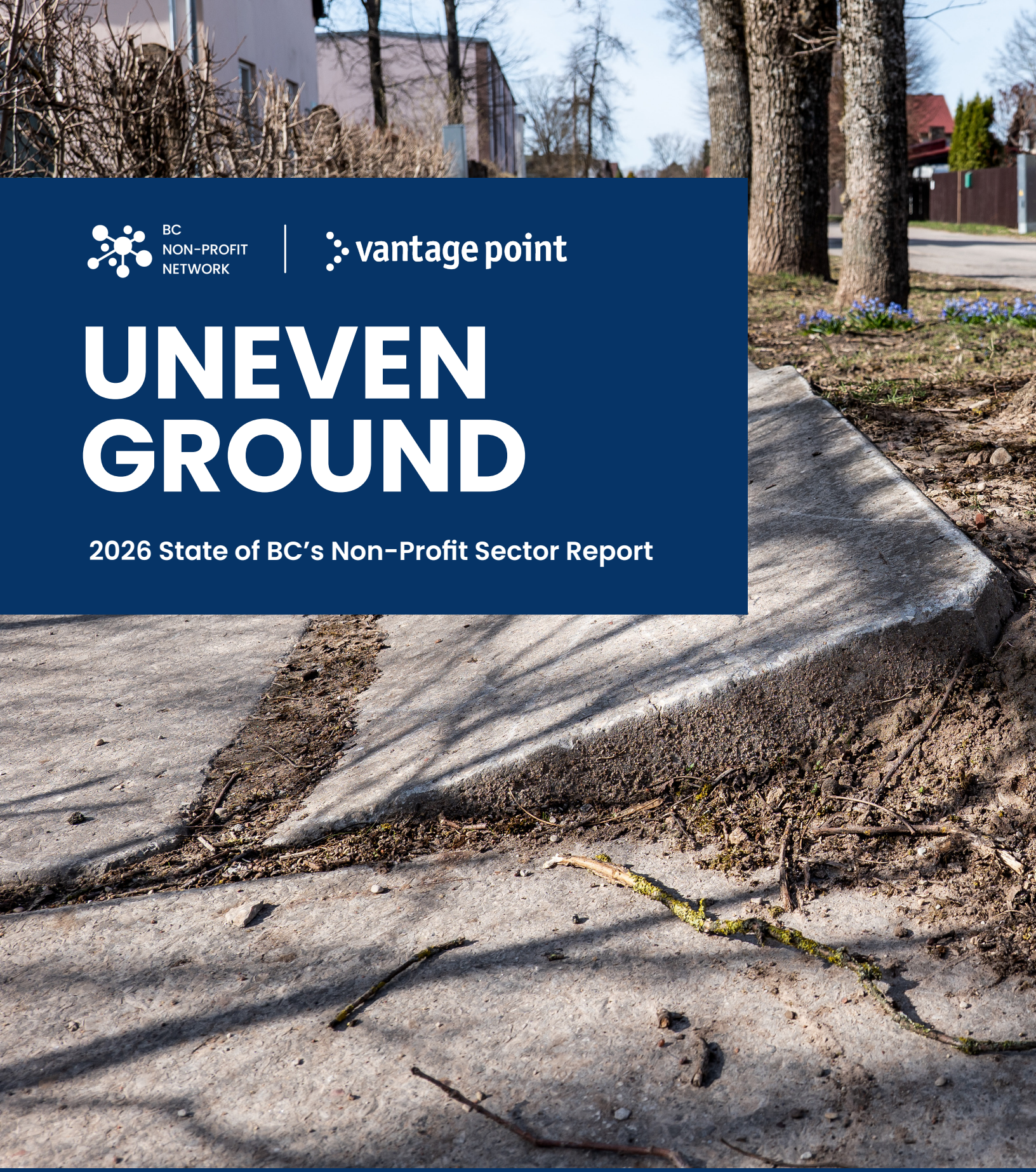


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2026 State of BC's Non-Profit Sector Report

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Insights to strengthen and sustain British Columbia's Non-Profit Sector

The State of BC's Non-Profit Sector Report series reveals the trends, challenges, and opportunities shaping over 32,000 non-profits across our province – highlighting areas where strategic investment can make the greatest impact.

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Contributors

Over 400 organizations responded to the 2026 State of BC's Non-Profit Sector Survey to provide their experiences and insights. Thank you to the working group and everyone who completed the survey and supported the work of making this year's data and report possible.

About Vantage Point and the BC Non-Profit Network

Vantage Point's vision is an inclusive community, where non-profits can achieve their fullest potential and drive sustainable change throughout the province and beyond.

We promote connected communities by nurturing a strong non-profit sector. We achieve this by delivering high-quality training, resources, and advocacy that build connection, creativity, and impact in the sector.

BC NON-PROFIT NETWORK

brought together by vantage point

The BC Non-Profit Network (BCNN) is a broad, cross-sectoral group that includes provincial and umbrella organizations, registered charities and societies, non-profit cooperatives, social enterprises, industry organizations, and other entities supporting public benefit in BC. Convened by Vantage Point, these organizations come together to address issues that impact all non-profits in British Columbia.

The BCNN's purpose is to:

- Convene & connect non-profit organizations
- Conduct sector-wide research and data collection
- Advocate on behalf of the non-profit sector
- Be a voice to government on behalf of the non-profit sector
- Raise the profile of the non-profit sector

We achieve this through sector surveys, polls, and knowledge mobilization, in-person events and online convergences, virtual Peer Communities, government relations, policy development, and collective advocacy.

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Summary

British Columbia's non-profit sector is made up of organizations of many sizes and scopes. Together, they strengthen communities across the province and work to ensure that vital supports reach the people who need them. Much of the sector's resilience in a world of increasingly rapid changes comes from the diversity and flexibility in resourcing and service delivery models across non-profits. Last year's report, *Stretched Thin*, showed how non-profits were being stretched by increasing demand volume and complexity, alongside rising expenses. This year, those pressures persist. But the same diversity that strengthens the sector also means pressures land differently, and organizations are coping in different ways depending on their operating contexts. This report takes a closer look at those contexts and how they have shifted over the past year.

The Sector-Wide Squeeze

Nearly nine in ten respondents (86%) reported increased demand for their services and four in five (83%) reported that the needs they are meeting have become more complex or severe. At the same time, costs rose near-universally: **nearly four in five organizations (79%) reported higher total expenses,** with increases across every expense category measured, including both administrative and direct service costs.

Yet, revenue did not rise uniformly. **While 39% of non-profits saw revenue increase, an equal 39% saw it decline.** This gap between near-universal cost pressures and uneven revenue change has forced difficult choices across organizations. For instance, the most common responses among organizations with decreased revenue have been to **reduce or eliminate services (66%), intensify revenue diversification efforts (64%), and draw down financial reserves (59%).** Notably, staffing cuts came fourth, at 54%. This data makes clear that organizations recognize staff are essential to navigating the times we are in and are being reduced only as a last resort.

Limited Capacity is Impacting Community

A majority of respondents (59%) reported that community demand is beyond their organizational capacity. Broadly, staffing levels remained unchanged across most of the sector. However, among organizations with increased demand beyond capacity, roughly one in five had decreased staffing. When expanding staffing levels to respond to demand is not possible due to financial constraints, the most reported action is **referring and waitlisting clients.** Some non-profit organizations are shrinking their services and workforce.

Unequal Exposure Across Revenue Streams and Space

How organizations are funded shapes their vulnerability. Organizations **primarily dependent on federal grants** registered the clearest trend toward declining revenue, with a **near-majority (45%) reporting decreases.** In contrast, organizations primarily funded by **earned revenue or provincial government funding** held steadier.

Physical space also makes a difference. Facilities costs rose for 63% of respondents, but that majority swells to three in four (75%) for organizations that are **renting or leasing at market rates.** About a third of organizations renting at market rates described their existence as at-risk, compared to fewer than a tenth among organizations that own their space. For smaller organizations, renting at market rates is a particularly acute compounding pressure.

Sustainability Under Strain

Among this year's respondents, **three-quarters (74%) reported confidence** in their organizational sustainability beyond 12 months. However, among the smallest organizations operating under $300,000 annually, **41% rated their sustainability as at-risk,** compared to an average 14% among the largest organizations ($3 million or more). The smallest organizations are also more likely to be navigating smaller revenue bases, and to have exposure to less reliable secondary or tertiary funding sources.

How Organizations Are Responding

Faced with these pressures, non-profits are adapting in a myriad of ways. Smaller organizations have pursued strategic alliances, shared services, or merger and amalgamation at notably higher rates (~55%) than larger organizations (~42%), seeking resilience through collaboration. Across all organization sizes, 79% increased their use of AI and 61% increased investment in IT and data infrastructure, signalling the sector's openness to exploring potential technological lifts to offset capacity constraints.

At the same time, organizations are unsustainably absorbing demand or passing it on. Non-profits of all types rely on one another to serve the varied needs within each community. The pattern emerging is that when revenue tightens, organizations first reduce programs, services, and activities. These reductions ripple outward: organizations refer clients elsewhere or expand waitlists, shifting unmet need to other non-profits and agencies, or leaving it unmet altogether. For community members who depend on these services day in and day out, the consequence is real and immediate.

This report shows a sector where nearly all organizations face the same external pressures – rising demand, rising costs, revenue volatility, and strained capacities – but an organization's budget size, funding mix, and space arrangement reveal differences in how those pressures land. Strengthening the sector's collective resilience against these compounding pressures is essential to preserving BC's broader social infrastructure and supporting the well-being of BC's residents.

1. Introduction

According to the latest statistics available, in 2024, BC's non-profit sector accounted for 9.1% of the province's GDP, produced $36.4 billion in economic value, and employed some 397,000 workers (Imagine Canada, 2026). At the time of publication in October 2026, there are roughly 32,000 registered non-profits in BC (Ministry of Citizens' Services, 2026). This includes community, business, and government non-profits. This year's report provides a look into BC's community non-profits, the majority of the survey's respondents.

Community Non-Profits

In 2024, community non-profits contributed $6.08 billion to BC's GDP (17% of the sector's total $36.4 billion) (Statistics Canada, 2026c). Although there is no official count of the number of community non-profits, given that 56% of BC's non-profit sector is entirely volunteer-run (Statistics Canada, 2024), it is likely that community non-profits make up the majority of the total number of non-profits in BC.

In addition to engaging volunteers, community non-profits employ 25% of the entire sector's workforce (Imagine Canada, 2026). In 2021, this workforce was 65% female, 31% immigrants, 6% Indigenous, and 34% visible minorities (Statistics Canada, 2023), and it was primarily concentrated in the social services, education, and research subsectors, followed by religion, culture, and recreation (Statistics Canada, 2026b). Primary revenue sources for community non-profits are government ($5.1 billion), earned income ($5.0 billion), corporate donations and inter-subsector transfers between non-profits ($585 million) (Imagine Canada, 2026).

This year, we asked our survey respondents to quantify their community impact. Most respondents have pushed through rising costs and rising demand to continue serving their communities, collectively circulating an estimated $1.134 billion into BC's economy[1] and employing approximately 34,000 workers.[2] Yet this report also shows where the system is under strain – which funding sources are eroding, how organizations are managing demand, impacts on the non-profit workforce, and which organizations are facing challenges with sustainability.

This report proceeds through four sections: **Split Revenues**, examining how different revenue streams are trending and how organizations are responding to revenue losses and gains; **Workforce**, exploring staffing changes and the hard-to-fill skills gaps organizations are reporting; **Sustainability**, documenting which organizations are most at-risk and what actions they are taking; and **Looking Forward**, presenting the challenges and opportunities that non-profits anticipate. Throughout, the data shows both the uniform pressures all non-profits face and the varied capacity to respond based on organizational context.

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1 This is an estimation using the number of respondents per budget band (i.e. under $300K, $300K to under $1M, $1M to under $3M, $3M to under $5M, $5M to under $10M, and $10M+), multiplied by the midpoint values of each budget band (i.e. $150K, $650K, $2M, $4M, $7.5M, and $12.5M as a conservative midpoint used for the $10M+ budget band). 417 respondents reported their budget bands: 379 (90%) are community non-profits; 11 (3%) are government non-profits; 11 (3%) are business non-profits; 16 (4%) are funders. The sum of these midpoint estimates per budget band is $1,134,300,000.

2 This is also a midpoint estimation using the midpoints of the reported ranges for number of employees (i.e. 0 or entirely volunteer-run, 1-4, 5-19, 20-99, 100+). 399 respondents reported the range for number of employees. The sum of these midpoint estimates is 33,640.5.

About the Respondents

This mid-year 2026 snapshot is made possible by more than 400 non-profit organizations operating across BC. Nearly a quarter (23%, n=97) operate at a provincial scope, while almost two-thirds (65%, n=275) serve local communities, from the Capital Regional District (n=68) to Vancouver (n=65) and beyond. The majority (72%, n=296) are urban-serving.[3]

To make sense of an organization's size, the respondents reported the budget tier that best reflects their annual operating budget.[4] This year's sample splits almost evenly across four tiers (roughly 25% each):

Smallest organizations	under $300,000 (under $300K)
Small organizations	$300,000 to under $1 million ($300K to <$1M)
Mid-sized organizations	$1 million to under $3 million ($1M to <$3M)
Largest organizations	$3 million or more ($3M+)

That means every size of non-profit, from the smallest grassroots groups to multi-million-dollar organizations, is represented in roughly equal numbers, giving us a clear view across the whole spectrum of community non-profits through this year's sample. The data offers a balanced look at how experiences diverge across the sector, and is the main lens used in this year's analysis.

Small and Mighty Sample

Together, our respondent organizations represent far more than simply this year's survey sample. In the past 12 months alone, respondents collectively served more than 6 million clients (not necessarily unique individuals)[5] and supported some 23,000 organizations.[6] They are most commonly social services organizations (38%), followed by health (15%), arts and culture (12%), education (8%), and housing (7%).[7] The populations most commonly served by them are seniors, youth, and people with disabilities and chronic health conditions. This is only a fraction of what BC's non-profits contribute to the province every day. It is also representative of the social infrastructure that is at stake.

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3 In our sample, there are nearly 3 urban non-profits for every 1 rural non-profit. The share of rural/small town area vs. urban area non-profits in BC was 14.4% vs. 85.6% for 2023; that is about 1 rural non-profit for every 6 urban-serving. Source: https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/n1/daily-quotidien/260313/cg-f001-eng.htm

4 Annual operating budget: A 12-month financial plan estimating an organization's planned revenues and recurring operational expenses. It measures the day-to-day costs of running programs, maintaining staff, and keeping facilities operational.

5 The sum of number of clients served in the past 12 months, among respondents that provided an estimation, is 6,847,792. An individual can access more than one non-profit and be a client at multiple non-profits. This is not a count of unique individuals.

6 The sum of number of organizations served in the past 12 months, among respondents that provided an estimation, is 23,572. This is also not a count of unique organizations.

7 The subsector composition of BC's non-profit sector is sports and recreation (39%), religion (18%), grant-making, fundraising and voluntarism promotion (9%). Source: https://doi.org/10.25318/3310075301-eng.

About the Survey

Methodology	The State of BC's Non-Profit Sector Survey was circulated province-wide between May and June 2026 through snowball sampling. After data cleaning, 426 respondents answered at least one of the survey's core analytical questions, forming the basis for this report's sector-wide findings. Note: the n number (sample size) varies by question due to skip logic and partial question completions.
Focus	The primary focus of the survey is to understand change across six core areas of organizational health (Revenues, Expenses, Services, Human Resources, Operations, and Governance), by asking respondents to report if an aspect within these six areas has *decreased*, *stayed the same*, or *increased*.

How to Read this Report

Respondents reported whether each organizational aspect, from specific revenue sources to staffing levels, had decreased, stayed the same, or increased over the previous 12 months.

A **"majority trend"** is identified where a majority (51%+) of respondents reported the same direction of change. It highlights when a change is widespread among respondents, and therefore represents a sector-wide trend. A **"near-majority"** trend is when there are 45-50% of respondents reporting the same direction of change.

Percentages in this report are **prevalence rates** that show how many organizations reported a decrease, no change, or an increase in each aspect. **They do not indicate the size or magnitude of that change.** For example, "39% reported decreased revenue" means 39% of organizations checked the "decreased" box for total revenue; it does not mean that total revenues in the sector fell by 39%. A decrease or increase is sometimes differentiated as "slight" or "significant."

A Note on Correlation

This report **does not** make claims about correlation**.** When two findings are presented together, for example, budget size alongside sustainability risk, this reflects patterns observed side-by-side in this year's data, not a statistical test of the relationship. No correlation, regression, or significance testing has been applied anywhere in the analysis.

For more information about the survey, please view the appendix online:
https://thevantagepoint.ca/sector-reports/

Trends at a Glance: Changes in the previous 12 months

As a quick reference, this section summarizes the trends observed among respondents, providing insights into what BC's non-profit sector likely experienced between spring 2025 and spring 2026 and showing which organizational aspects decreased, increased, or were unchanged. Some organizational aspects are a "near-majority"; this means that the prevalence rate is between 45% and 50%. Since this is within six percentage points of a majority (i.e. 51% and above), it indicates a trend worth watching.

↑ INCREASED ORGANIZATIONAL ASPECTS

Nearly half (45%) of all measured aspects increased. They are concentrated in expense categories (both direct and administrative costs), community demand (volume and severity/complexity of needs), and operational and governance investments. Organizations are turning to efficiency tools, with increased AI usage and increased investment in IT and data infrastructure.

Expenses

- Total expenses 79%
- Administration 66%
- Service delivery 71%
- Salaries 75%
- Marketing 47%
- Contractor fees 53%
- Facilities 63%
- Benefits 60%
- Capital 65%
- Unexpected costs 58%

Services/Programs/Activities

- Demand 86%
- Complexity/severity of needs 83%
- Range of offerings 52%
- Investment in relationship-building, outreach, and/or collaborations 74%
- AI use 79%

HR

- Salaries/wages level 63%

Operations & Governance

- Investment in marketing, communications, and public relations 50%
- Investment in fund development 61%
- Investment in board governance and recruitment 52%
- Investment in strategic, scenario, or contingency planning 56%
- Investment in IT, AI adoption, data management, cybersecurity 61%

↔ UNCHANGED ORGANIZATIONAL ASPECTS

Over one-third (36%) of measured aspects showed no change over the past year, mostly in human resources. This suggests that HR functions have been relatively stable and organizations met rising demand largely by working within existing staffing and hours of availability. Two revenue sources – provincial and municipal government funding – also held flat for a majority of organizations that have these sources. Note that unchanged revenue dollars may represent a real decrease once inflation is factored in.

Revenues

- Provincial funding 48%
- Municipal funding 48%
- External financing 62%

Services/Programs/Activities

- Hours of availability 53%
- Investment in evaluation/impact measurement 51%
- Investment in climate adaptation 59%

HR

- Investment in professional development 49%
- PT staffing 46%
- FT staffing 47%
- Staff absences 58%
- Benefit level 56%
- Turnover rate 56%
- Time-to-fill[8] 46%

Operations & Governance

- Investment in funder reporting 57%
- Investment in diversity, belonging, reconciliation, or accessibility 56%
- Investment in advocacy, lobbying and government relations 48%
- Investment in strategic alliances, shared services, or merger/amalgamation 48%

When Revenues are Unchanged

Unchanged revenue dollars represent a real decrease in purchasing power. In inflationary periods, "no change" in funding should be read as a loss of funding, not as stability. This is particularly important when interpreting provincial and municipal funding trends, where the same funding dollars alongside rising costs signal increasing financial pressure.

8 Time-to-fill: A measure of how long hiring periods last for an organization, from the start of recruitment to when positions are filled. It is an indicator used to assess workforce health, talent market conditions, and employer value propositions.

↑↓ MIXED SIGNALS

There was no majority of respondents that reported the same directional change for any of the following organizational aspects (i.e. no observable trend). Most are revenue sources, and just two aspects are HR-related: number of contractors (including temporary/seasonal staff and students), and number of volunteers.

	Decreased	Unchanged	Increased
Revenues			
Total revenue	39%	22%	39%
Federal government	40%	35%	24%
Donations	33%	29%	37%
Earned revenue	25%	33%	43%
Foundations	28%	42%	30%
Corporations	35%	38%	27%
Investment income	25%	42%	32%
HR			
Contractor staffing	17%	42%	41%
Volunteers	15%	43%	42%

↓ DECREASED ORGANIZATIONAL ASPECTS

No organizational aspect showed decline trends, but two revenue aspects had the largest shares of organizations reporting decreases: 1) federal funding (40% reported declines, n=88), and 2) total revenue (39% reported declines, n=145).

Reading the Sector's Mood

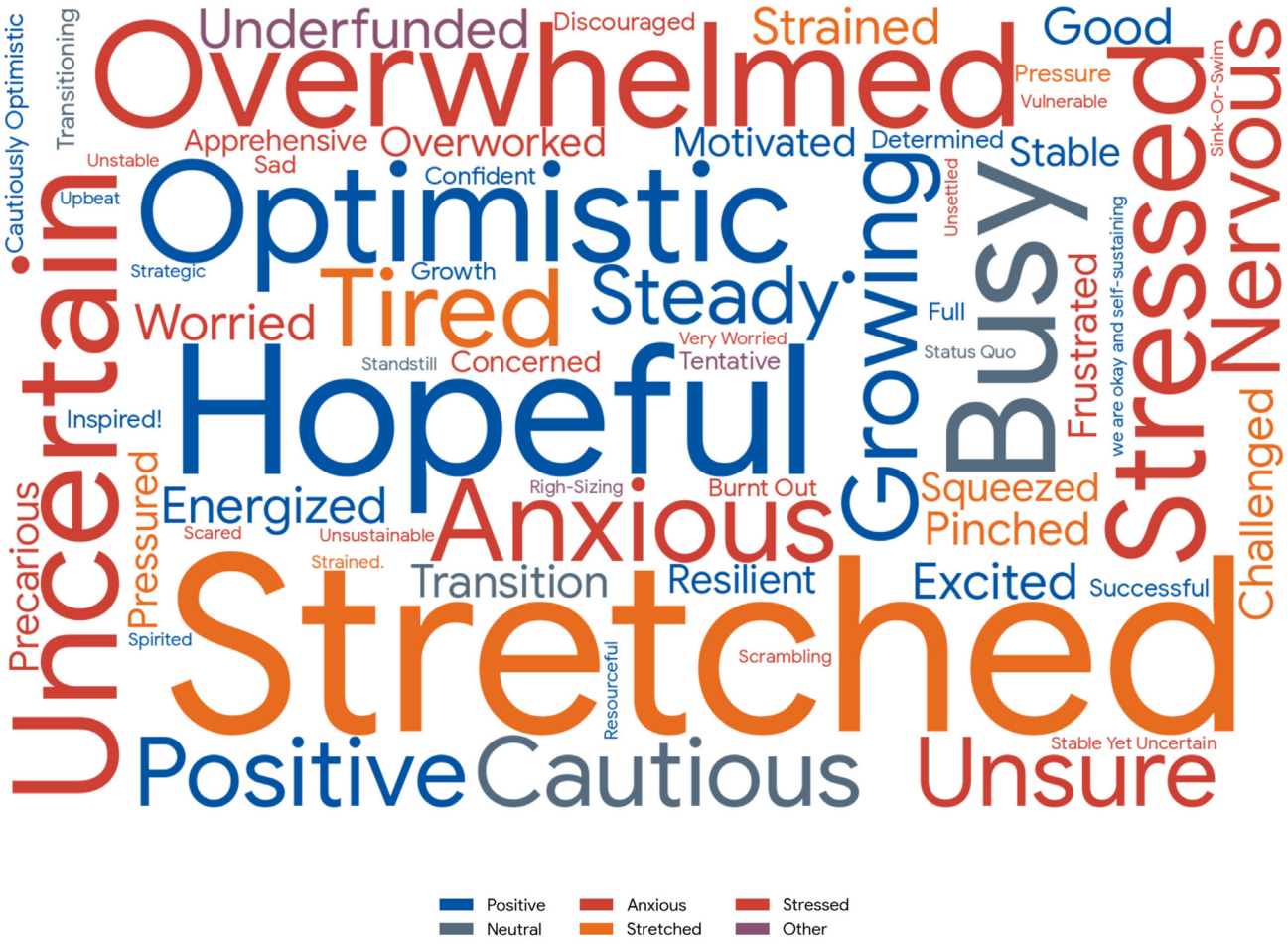
IN SHORT

More than half (53%) of the respondents described their organization's current mood in negative terms. About a third (30%) reported feeling positively, and the remainder felt neutral or mixed.

- Positive moods are mostly about feeling optimistic and hopeful, and negative moods are stretched, stressed, and anxious.
- The largest organizations are more likely to feel stretched, while the smallest organizations feel stressed and anxious. Large organizations are not immune to strain and being pulled thin, but smaller organizations are disproportionately grappling with anxiety and stress.

Each year, before any numbers are cross-tabulated, or any trends calculated, this survey asks a simple question: **how does it feel to be a non-profit in BC right now?** The answer is an early signal for everything that the rest of the survey data later confirms.

Figure 1.1 Sentiment Word Cloud



Just over half of respondents (53%, N=412) described their organization's mood in negative terms: feeling stretched (23%), stressed (16%), or anxious (14%). About a third (30%) struck a more positive note: mostly feeling optimistic (13%) and hopeful (5%). The remainder (17%) fell outside the positive/negative binary, describing their mood in mixed or neutral terms. On the surface, this looks like a straightforward story: a sector under strain, with negativity outweighing optimism. A more layered story emerges below the surface when the sentiments are broken down by budget tiers.

Table 1.1 Sentiment Prevalence Among All Respondents

	Majority Trend	Remaining Sentiments		
All Respondents	Negative (Stretched, Stressed, Anxious) 53%	Positive 30%	Neutral 11%	Other 6%

While negative sentiment remains the most common response overall across every budget size, positive sentiment was somewhat more common among organizations between $300K to under $1M (37% versus 30%). This is a modest but notable bright spot.

A closer look at the negative sentiments reveals a crucial difference. The largest organizations, those with $3M or more, hold the highest prevalence rate of feeling stretched, at 34%. This suggests capacity strained thin, resources pulled in too many directions, but not necessarily a sense of fear for the organization's future. The other two negative sentiments, stressed and anxious, carry a heavier undertone of worry. **It is the smallest organizations, those under $300K, that most frequently report feeling stressed (31%) and anxious (29%). In contrast, only 17% of the largest organizations report feeling stressed.** This is the survey's first clear signal of the sector's differences.

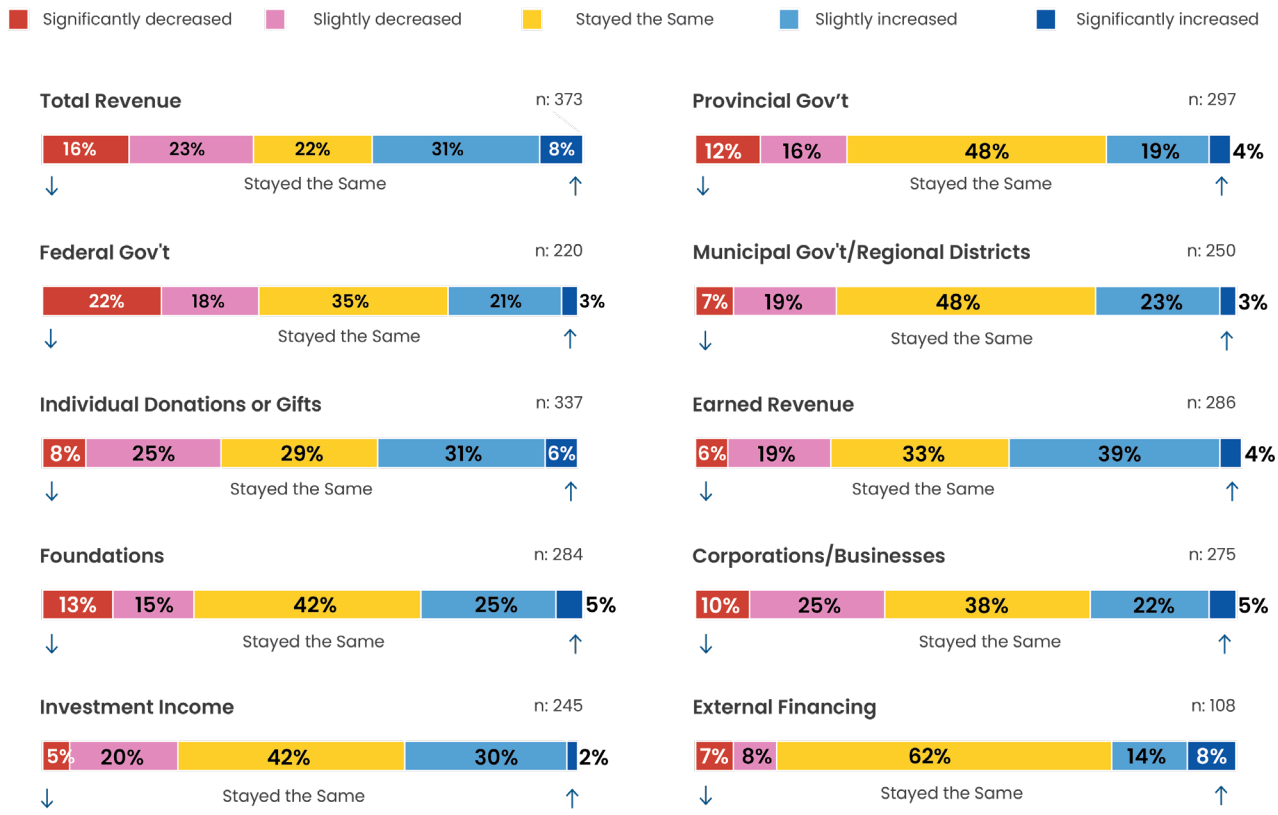
2. Split Revenues: The cost-of-operating squeeze

IN SHORT

The revenue picture among respondents is split between 39% with decreases and 39% with increases.

Costs rose across every category for most respondents, accompanied by surging demand for community services. But while expenses were higher, total revenue change was evenly divided between 39% of organizations with increases, and 39% of organizations with decreases.

Figure 2.1 Share of Respondents with Decreased, Unchanged, Increased Revenues by Revenue Streams



Among organizations whose revenue decreased, roughly 65% still saw their expenses rise (i.e. their revenue decline was not offset by lowered expenses). As many as 78% of organizations whose revenue was unchanged faced increased costs anyway. **In other words, rising costs were close to universal this year, but the ability to keep pace with them was not.** That gap, between an expense reality nearly every respondent shared and a revenue reality that divided the sector into two dominant groups, raises questions about organizations' different abilities to balance their books by fiscal year-end.

Cutting once again by budget tiers (Table 2.1 below), organizations with $10M+ budgets mostly saw revenues increase (56%), as did those between $3M and under $5M (49%, a near-majority). At the opposite end, organizations under $300K were the only group with a clear near-majority (48%) moving the other direction with decreased revenues. Every band in between sits without a clear trend. This raises questions about direct access to funders and partners among smaller organizations, as well as the capacity to write winning grants and pull audiences for annual giving strategies (monthly giving, fundraising events, etc.).

Table 2.1 Share of Organizations Across Changes in Total Revenues by Budget Tiers

	Decreased	Unchanged	Increased	Majority Trend
All Respondents	39%	22%	39%	None: Split
Under $300K	48%	25%	27%	Near-majority Decreased
$300K to under $1M	42%	16%	43%	None: Split
$1M to under $3M	36%	26%	38%	None: Split
$3M to under $5M	24%	27%	49%	Near-majority Increased
$5M to under $10M	39%	26%	35%	None: Split
$10M+	33%	10%	56%	Increased

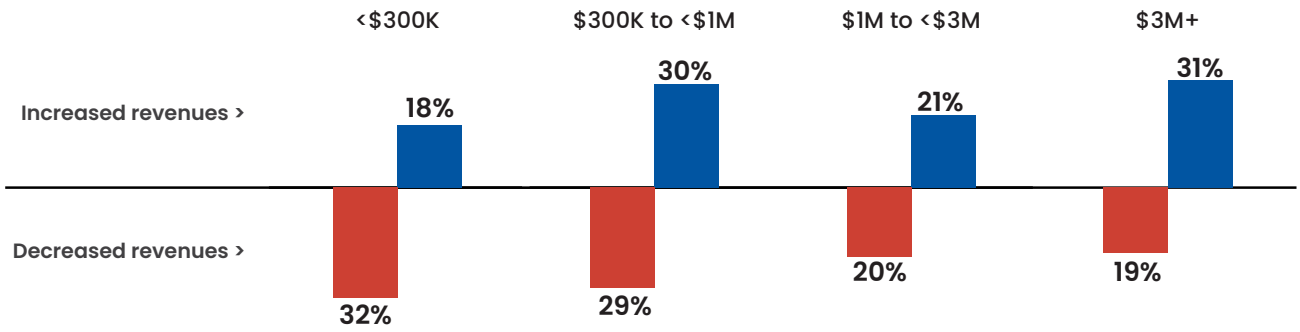
Note: In the table above, “None: Split” means that there is no majority trend and instead, there are similar shares of respondents split between two categories (e.g. 42% decreased, 43% increased).

Organizations with Decreased Total Revenues vs. Increased Revenues

Organizations with Decreased Total Revenues

Among the 39% of respondents with decreased total revenues, two out of five organizations classified this decrease as "significantly decreased," and the remainder classified it as "slightly decreased." As shown by the chart below in red bars, the majority of them (61%) operated with less than $1M.

Figure 2.2 Share of Organizations with Decreased Total Revenues (Red) vs. Increased Total Revenues (Blue) by Budget Tiers



For organizations with *significantly decreased revenues*, all measured revenue sources, other than corporations, investments, and financing, reported a decreased trend (the bracket figures indicate how many reported "significantly decreased" and "slightly decreased"):

- **Provincial government funding** (52% significant vs. 13% slight)
- **Federal government funding** (74% significant vs. 9% slight)
- **Foundation funding** (30% significant vs. 21% slight)

In terms of organizational investments, most measured investments stayed the same among this subset of organizations. Some investments, however, increased: fund development (70%), strategic planning (55%), technology (50%), and collaboration (58%). **The majority of these organizations also reported that full-time staffing levels decreased. Further, 35% reported decreased levels of services offered, and 37% reported decreased hours of services.** When organizations experience decreased revenues, this coincides with reduced staffing and capacity to deliver community services.

Organizations with Increased Total Revenues

The most common budget tiers among this subset of organizations with increased revenues are $300K to under $1M (30%) and $3M+ (31%) (see blue bars in Figure 2.2). The smallest organizations were least represented in this group (18%), followed by those from $1M to under $3M (21%).

Among them, the following revenue sources had a majority or near-majority that reported an increased trend (the bracket figures indicate how many reported "slightly increased" vs. "significantly increased"):

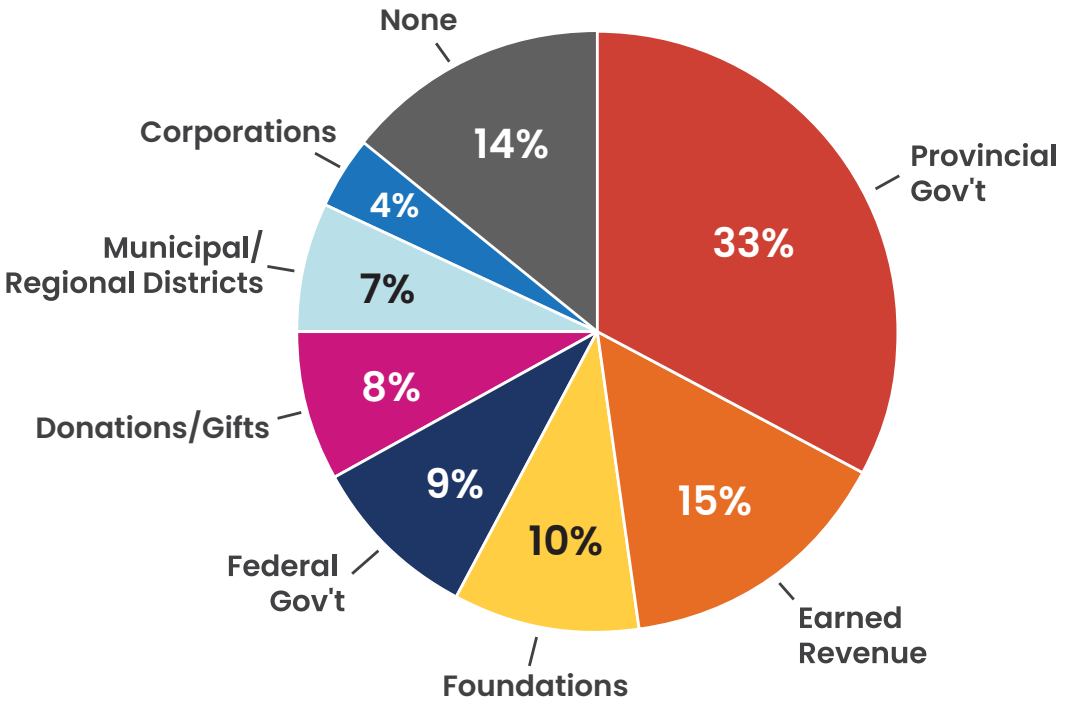
- **Earned revenue** (53% slight vs. 7% significant)
- **Donations** (48% slight vs. 11% significant)
- **Foundations** (39% slight vs. 10% significant)
- **Corporations** (36% slight vs. 11% significant)
- **Provincial government funding** (35% slight vs. 10% significant)

For these organizations, human resources capacity actually increased. **Full-time staffing levels were reported as increased for 45% of them, and part-time staffing increased for 55%.** What does this mean for the communities they support? An unmistakable **72% reported increased service levels and a near-majority (49%) expanded service hours.** When organizations have greater financial resources, the data suggests that they translate these gains into more frontline programs and services for communities.

Weighing by Primary Source

Given that the primary revenue source holds extra weight in total financial growth or decline, analyzing the distinct funding models of small versus large organizations provides some critical insight into the different revenue outcomes.

Figure 2.3 Primary Revenue Sources Among All Respondents



As the chart above shows, funding from the provincial government is the leading primary source among this year's respondents, accounting for 33% of organizations' primary revenue source (Figure 2.3). Only three primary revenue sources show a near-majority trend in total revenues:

- Earned revenue: Near-majority **increased** total revenue (50%, n=50)
- Federal government funding: Near-majority **decreased** total revenue (45%, n=34)
- Foundations: Near-majority **decreased** total revenue (46%, n=37)

Earned revenue seems to have more growth potential than other revenue sources for respondents. In contrast, organizations that are primarily funded through federal government or foundation funding may have been more exposed to tightened revenues this past year.

The analysis of primary revenue sources and revenue trends between small and large organizations shows that among larger organizations, primary funding remained dependable. Over 75% of large, primarily-provincially-funded organizations saw revenues hold steady or increase (40% unchanged; 36% increased). Earned revenue similarly drove growth, with 48% of mid-sized organizations reporting gains. Large organizations also experienced strong stability under federal government funding, with 90% seeing funding remain flat (50%) or grow (40%).

However, among smaller organizations, those primarily federally funded faced drops, with 45% reporting significant cuts (contrasting sharply with larger organizations). The primary funding source for smaller organizations in this sample is not the provincial government, but rather, foundations, donations, and municipal governments. Most of these sources held relatively stable. Yet, overall revenues declined. It is likely that drops occurred in secondary and tertiary funding streams. Because small organizational budgets have so little cushion to begin with, even a decline in a source that is not the main revenue generator can be enough to tip an organization from stable into deficit. In other words, small non-profits likely suffered losses across revenue streams that are needed to round out their budgets, leaving them vulnerable.

The Newer vs. Older Debate

Within each budget tier, organizational age adds its own layer to the story, though not in a clean, straightforward way. There is no clear evidence that newer or older organizations are, across the board, getting respectively less or more funding. Instead, among this survey's respondents, smaller organizations are more likely to experience decreased total revenues if they are more established, and large organizations are more likely to experience increased total revenues if they are more established.

These insights taken together demonstrate how no single factor - not budget size alone, nor age alone - fully explains which BC non-profits are more resilient, and which are struggling this year. Intersectionality matters not only for individuals, but also for organizations - it's the *combination* of factors shaping operational contexts that matters. The data demonstrates that now, more than ever, we must understand non-profits through nuanced lenses that move beyond rigid stereotypes and single-dimension expectations.

3. Workforce: Stability on the surface

IN SHORT

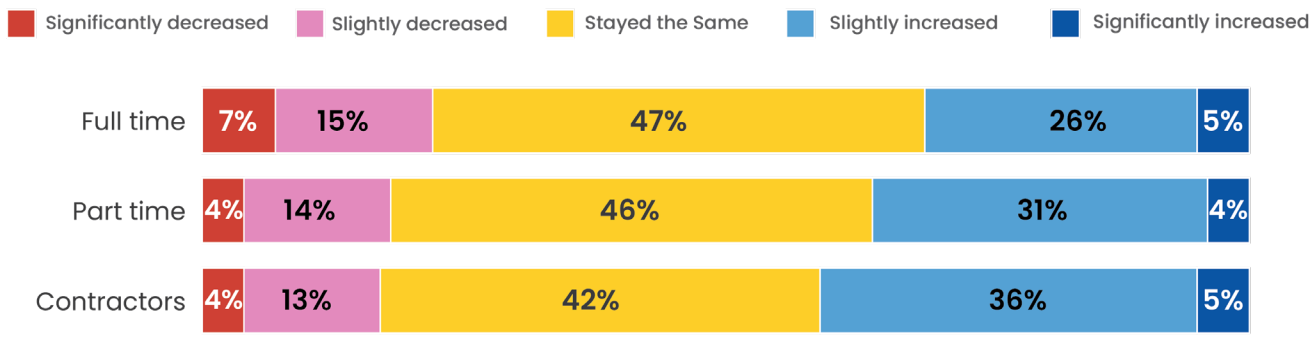
Staffing decisions reflected revenue trajectories, and *not* community needs. Staffing levels held steady for most, and the exceptions reveal an underlying financial divide: organizations with increased revenues grew their staff; organizations with significantly decreased revenues (predominantly the smallest non-profits) cut both full-time and part-time positions. The broad middle of the sector had little change.

- Demand is rising across the sector, and most feel it is beyond their capacity to respond. Staffing mostly did not grow to meet growing demand, and in fact, roughly one in five non-profits facing demand beyond their capacity decreased staffing even as demand grew. When expanding staffing levels to respond to demand is not possible, organizations are referring and waitlisting clients.
- The smallest organizations are more likely than large organizations to have invested in strategic alliances, shared services, or merger/amalgamation - seeking to join forces where possible.

Across all respondents, staffing levels, both full-time and part-time, largely held steady this year (wide yellow bars in Figure 3.1 below). That steadiness breaks down, however, **among organizations whose *total revenue significantly decreased*: a majority cut full-time staffing, and nearly half (46%) reduced part-time staffing** as well. As established earlier, these are disproportionately the smaller non-profits. Workforce cuts, like revenue losses themselves, are landing unevenly across the sector.

Outside of the significantly-decreased-revenues group, the picture is calmer. Organizations whose revenue slightly decreased, stayed flat, or slightly increased show no clear majority trend in staffing. The one other clear signal comes from the opposite extreme: among the few **organizations whose *revenue significantly increased*, a majority added staff: 57% grew full-time staffing levels, 68% grew part-time, and 84% increased contractors.** Staffing, in other words, moved up or down only at the edges this year, while the broad middle of the sector stayed largely unchanged.

Figure 3.1 Changes in Staffing Levels in the Past 12 Months



Do Organizations Cut Staff When Revenues Decline?
Yes, but not as the first response. Among the 39% of respondents that reported decreased total revenue this year, the most frequent responses were:

- Reduced or eliminated services (66%)
- Stepped up revenue diversification efforts (64%)
- Drew down financial reserves* (59%)
- Reduced staffing (54%)

When revenue decreases, the most common impact is on the community, **with programs and services reduced or removed.**

*Note: Tapping into reserves was a viable option for most of the respondents: 78% of respondents (n=263) have some form of reserve, though 7% have none at all, and a further 4% hold a reserve that isn't accessible for operating costs (the remaining 11% were unsure). Where reserves exist, most (58%) can cover somewhere between 1 and 6 months of operating costs. This is a buffer, but not a long one, and use of reserves hinders the ability of an organization to make necessary future investments, withstand future crises, or pay for dissolution-related costs.

Unevenness shows up again in how organizations have pivoted structurally during a period of sustained growing demand. Smaller organizations turned to investing in strategic alliances, shared services, or mergers and amalgamations at markedly higher rates than their larger counterparts: 53% of organizations under $300K and 57% of those from $300K to under $1M reported pursuing this kind of collaboration, compared to just 39% among $1M–under $3M organizations and 45% among those with $3M+ budgets. Smaller organizations appear to be reaching for a different kind of resilience: combining forces rather than going it alone.

A Sector Stretched by Demand, Not Just Dollars

Underneath these staffing numbers is a story of rising demand that helps explain why so many organizations felt stretched even as their finances held steady or grew. **Nearly nine in ten respondents (86%, N=357) reported increased demand** for their programs or services this year: just over half (54%) characterized this as "slightly increased," and nearly another half (46%) as "significantly increased." **A majority (59%) also classified demand as beyond their capacity.** Among organizations with slightly increased demand, the majority (51%) felt it is beyond their capacity; among organizations facing significantly increased demand, this shoots up to 81% or four in five organizations.

The table below looks specifically at all the organizations that reported increased demand that is beyond their capacity (n=213), and asks: **did staffing grow to meet that pressure?** Not for most of them. Across all three staffing types measured (full-time employees, part-time employees, and contractors), roughly the same three-way pattern holds: about 4 in 10 organizations kept staffing unchanged (~44%), roughly a third increased it (~35%), and about a fifth decreased it (~21%).

Table 3.1 Staffing Level Changes among Organizations with Increased Demand that is Beyond Capacity

Type of Staffing	% Decreased	% Unchanged	% Increased
Full-time staffing	22%	43%	35%
Part-time staffing	21%	45%	34%
Contractors	20%	43%	36%

This paints a fuller picture of what "stretched" means in practice: as rising demand continues, the capacity to meet demand is only expanding for the few organizations that have the revenue to increase staffing. For everyone else, doing more with the same or with less isn't a metaphor; it is their unsustainable operating reality.

The most common adaptive action among the survey respondents experiencing demand that is higher than capacity is to **expand staffing where possible** (mentioned by 24% of respondents). **Referring clients to other organizations (22%) and waitlisting (20%)** are also common courses of action. In the qualitative responses, organizations shared common remarks about how the demand is not being met but transferred to other organizations or being absorbed, in unsustainable ways, by the clients (e.g. being placed on waitlists or filtered through tighter eligibility criteria), or by staff (who are working more without increases in compensation). The sector's lack of capacity to meet rising demand is impacting its workforce and the community at large.

Capacity-Building Needs Beyond Funding

IN SHORT

- BC non-profits need technology and digital infrastructure to support capacity. They are likely operating with systems and tools that need updating and, if updated, would improve program/service delivery and operations.
- The top workforce skills gaps are clinical, health, and direct service skills (this may be reflective of the fact that social services organizations are best represented in the sample). Smaller organizations, however, have more varied needs across administrative functions, including finance, operations, and marketing/communications.
- Formal leadership succession planning is not prevalent among respondents, but informal and partial plans are common. Respondents are able to assess the risk (likelihood) of a leadership transition but may not necessarily have the capacity to proactively and formally plan for it.

Ask BC's non-profits what they need most, and unsurprisingly, funding and staffing top the list. This year's respondents point to additional capacity-building needs beyond funding and staffing: **technology, software, and digital infrastructure rank as the top additional need**, cited by 43% of respondents. Non-profits with fixed capacities are curious about and seeking operational lifts from technology. Ranking close behind is staff skills development and training, echoing a persistent HR challenge respondents also raised in last year's survey: it is difficult to hire staff with the needed skills.

To dig into that challenge, this year we asked respondents to indicate the skills that are hardest to find, up to three each. Respondents mentioned 795 individual skills, which are grouped into ten categories:

Table 3.2 Top Needed Skill Categories Identified by Respondents

Skill Category	% of Respondents
Clinical, Health & Direct Service	31%
Interpersonal & Soft Skills	27%
Administration, Finance & Operations	27%
Communications & Marketing	26%
Leadership & Management	21%
Other/Specialized*	20%
Fundraising & Fund Development	20%
Program Development, Delivery & Evaluation	15%
Technology, AI & Digital Tools	15%
Human Resources & People Management	7%

Note: The most frequently mentioned skill clusters within "Other/Specialized" are: 1) Trades, facilities, food service & driving, 2) Environmental science, animals, land, 3) Languages and bilingualism, 4) Arts and cultural performance and production.

Roughly one in three organizations named a skill in the Clinical, Health & Direct Service category. This is hardly a surprise given how heavily social services organizations are represented in this year's sample. That need is most concentrated among the largest organizations, and it dominates not just their first-choice skill gap, but their second and third as well.

Smaller organizations under $1M have more scattered requirements. Their needs spread fairly evenly across most categories, but with two clear exceptions that have close to no mentions: HR & People Management and Program Development, Delivery & Evaluation. For Technology, AI & Digital Tools skills: smaller organizations reported needing these at a notably higher rate (15%) than larger organizations. The fact that technology and digital infrastructure is a top capacity need, but digital skills were nearly never mentioned by larger organizations, suggests that **organizations' overall technology need is less about *skills* and more about *access* to digital infrastructure.**

Interestingly, the second most cited skill category across all respondents, tied with administration, finance and operations, is interpersonal and soft skills. In a sector under this much pressure, it seems that what is hardest to find is the complement of credentials and disposition in team members. This could include skills such as conflict resolution, change management, and leadership. Finally, just over a tenth of all responses named a specific job title rather than a skill competency, such as nurses and licensed health professionals, frontline and community support workers, and early childhood educators. This raises the question: are these roles hard to fill because the necessary skills are genuinely scarce, or because these positions are difficult to staff for other reasons entirely, from compensation and working conditions to pre-employment training and burnout in high-demand frontline roles?

Succession Planning: No capacity left to prepare

Nearly four in ten respondents (39%) anticipate a leadership transition in the next 12 months, yet only 15% of them have a formal succession plan in place. The problem is worse for organizations that were already in a transition at the time of surveying: just 10% had a formal plan. Among all respondents, formal succession planning is rare (14%), and most organizations rely instead on informal or partial plans. This is yet another symptom of the sector's overloaded capacity. Organizations can see the storm coming but lack the bandwidth to prepare for it. When these transitions occur, institutional knowledge, relationships, and program continuity are transferred haphazardly.

4. Sustainability: From stressed to at-risk

IN SHORT

A sustainability crisis is concentrated in the sector's smallest organizations. While three-quarters of the sector feel confident about sustaining into the next year, a substantial minority of small organizations face real closure risk by mid-2027.

- Among all respondents, there are about 25% of organizations that rated their organizational sustainability beyond the next 12 months as at-risk, and about 75% are confident about their future.
- The smallest organizations are significantly more likely to be at-risk of closure by May/June 2027. For organizations from $300K to under $1M, those at-risk rise to 30%, and among organizations under $300K, to 41%. Comparatively, for organizations $1M+, it drops below 25%, to as low as 3% for organizations above $10M.
- Additionally, among organizations of the same budget size, those renting or leasing space at market rates are more likely to be at-risk, versus those that are accessing space at nominal or no cost.

The survey's sustainability confidence rating is derived by asking respondents: how confident are you about your organization's sustainability? Overall, most sounded assured, even as strain on the sector appears prevalent: three out of four respondents (74%, N=337) reported confidence beyond 12 months. Framed as a ratio (3:1), for every organization that rated its existence as at-risk by May/June 2027, nearly 3 organizations reported confidence in their sustainability. This is summarized in the table below.

Table 4.1 Share of Respondents that are Confident vs. At-Risk by May/June 2027 by Budget Size

	Confident	At-Risk	Ratio Confident: At Risk
All Respondents	**74%**	**26%**	**3:1**
$10M+	97%	3%	31:1
$5M to under $10M	81%	19%	4:1
$3M to under $5M	81%	19%	4:1
$1M to under $3M	83%	17%	5:1
$300K to under $1M	70%	30%	2:1
Under $300K	59%	41%	1:1

In the final column of Table 4.1, the ratio shows how many organizations reported sustainability confidence for every organization that rated its existence as at-risk by May/June 2027. The overall 3:1 ratio shifts sharply across tiers. At the top, the ratio is high: risk touches just 3% of organizations with budgets over $10M, a single organization out of 32, with sustainability confidence near universal at that level (97%). Moving down a tier,

the ratio drops to roughly 4 confident organizations for every 1 that feels at-risk, a lower number but still notably better than the average ratio. Once the $300K to under $1M tier is reached, the ratio drops to 2 to 1, and risk rises to 30% of organizations, and then to two in five (41%) for the smallest organizations, those under $300K. The smallest organizations are more than 13 times as likely to face closure within the next year as the largest ones. The sustainability rating helps explain why the smallest organizations are feeling stressed and anxious, as many are genuinely uncertain whether their organization will exist a year from now.

Why Should We Care if Small Organizations Close?

Non-profits of all sizes and types are essential to meeting the varied needs of our communities. While large organizations can build expansive programs and service systems that contribute large-scale impacts, small organizations strengthen local relationships and serve hard-to-reach populations and geographies. For instance, among this survey's rural-serving respondents, the majority are small non-profits (42% have budgets under $300K and 28% have budgets between $300K to under $1M).

Small organizations ensure that programs and services are effective for local conditions, and that the sector is robust enough to absorb localized shocks and events. Within our survey sample, respondents with under $300K budgets reported collectively serving an estimated 1.3 million clients over the past year. On average, this translates to approximately 23,000 non-unique clients per organization.

Another Fault Line: Operating space

Facilities costs increased for the majority of all respondents (63%, N=312), but that majority swells for organizations renting or leasing at market rates, where three in four (75%) saw their space costs climb (see Table 4.2 below). Compare this to organizations occupying space at nominal or no cost, where a smaller, though still substantial, 43% saw increases. The type of space arrangement impacts the severity of the pressure non-profits feel. Similarly, among organizations renting at market rates, 30% described their existence as at-risk, already above the sample-wide 26%. Among organizations that own their space outright, that figure drops to just 9%. Owning space appears to be a protective shield for non-profits.

Table 4.2 Prevalence of Organizations Facing Rising Facilities Costs and At-Risk by Space Type

Type of Space Ownership/Access/Use	Share of Organizations with Increased Facilities Cost	Share of Organizations At-Risk
Own Building Outright (Free and Clear)	45%	9%
Nominal/No Cost	43%	27%
Below-Market Lease	64%	21%
Market Rent/Commercial Lease	75%	30%

What happens when the two fault lines of budget size and space meet? Table 4.3 summarizes the findings. Among the smallest organizations with budgets under $300K, renting or leasing at market rates pushes sustainability risk to 55%. That risk drops to 30% for similarly sized organizations that are accessing nominal or no-cost space. That 30% is still notably high: it's more than three times the 9% risk rate among $1M to under $3M organizations with similarly low-cost access to space.

Table 4.3 Prevalence of At-Risk Non-Profits by Budget Tiers and Space Type

	% At-Risk (Overall)	% At-Risk When Renting/ Leasing at Market	% At-Risk When Space is Nominal or No Cost
All Respondents	**26%**	**30%**	**27%**
$10M+	3%	n too small to report	n too small to report
$5M to under $10M	19%	n too small to report	n too small to report
$3M to under $5M	19%	33%	n too small to report
$1M to under $3M	17%	33%	9%
$300K to under $1M*	30%	26%	27%
Under $300K	41%	55%	30%

*Note: Interestingly, in this budget tier, there is a similarly sized share of respondents at risk between those who rent/lease at market, and those who access space at nominal/no cost (26% and 27%). More research is needed to understand why.

For the smallest organizations, a costly space arrangement doesn't just add to financial pressure; it can be the difference between manageable strain and a threat to survival. In BC's tight real estate market, affordable physical space isn't just an operational privilege: it appears to be tied to organizational survival.

5. Looking Forward

This section presents the sector's main challenges and opportunities ahead, as reported by the sector leaders surveyed this year. Respondents were asked to name the primary challenge and opportunity they are expecting over the next 12 months.

Challenges

When BC non-profits look ahead to the coming year, most describe facing compounding challenges as community demand increasingly outpaces their operational capacity. Many of the key themes below are longstanding and familiar issues in the sector but are nonetheless important to reiterate as they are more relevant than ever (each theme is supported by respondent quotes).

Staffing and Compensation

One in four organizations point to staffing challenges: recruitment, retention, turnover, burnout, and wages they cannot lift far enough to compete. This is the most prominent theme. Organizations described wage pressure and funding constraints as the same problem: they cannot pay more without more money, and they cannot retain people without paying more.

> *"Retain staff as the cost of living continues to grow and we are unable to provide competitive compensation to keep key staff members."*

> *"Adequate administrative staffing levels and funding - which go hand in hand."*

Funding: Availability and Mechanisms

One in five organizations named funding, often with no further detail. Where organizations did elaborate, the recurring theme was not the total amount but funding mechanisms: short cycles, late confirmations, and money attached to programs rather than to the work of keeping an organization running.

> *"Funding is always our biggest challenge as 80% of our funding is secured year by year."*

> *"Funding and specifically operational/overhead funding. We can locate funding for programs but no funding for operations."*

Widening Gap Between Demand and Capacity

Roughly one in five organizations described an external pressure and an internal limit together in the same answer, and the most common pairing by far is rising community need set against the capacity to meet it.

> *"We expect increased demand for our services to outpace our available resources. Meeting growing community needs without expanding our team will be a constant struggle."*

> *"Responding to increased demand, in the face of limited resources and staff burnout."*

Administrative Load vs. Direct Service

Fifteen per cent of organizations identified internal financial management – including fundraising capability, revenue diversification, budget balancing, and deficit recovery. Distinct from overall funding availability, this burden reflects the labour of fund development. Respondents highlighted how the constant effort required to apply for and report on grants actively diverts time and resources away from services/programs/activities.

> *"Capacity to continue fundraising. There is so much more increased demand in applying, reporting, managing project-based funding that it takes a lot of internal resources to manage fundraising vs. focusing on program growth."*

> *"The amount of effort required to cobble together donations and social enterprise projects to maintain staffing and knowledge base we have."*

Growth

Thirteen per cent named strategy, planning, growth, or change management. Many described expansion rather than contraction: launching strategic plans, managing scale-up, stabilizing after a period of growth. Some organizations are growing, and growth brings its own challenges.

> *"Our primary challenge over the next 12 months will be balancing the growing demand and opportunity for expansion with the financial sustainability and infrastructure needed to support that growth responsibly."*

> *"Changes in our board of directors as we begin our strategic planning process. The last 6 years have been about growth, I suspect our next three years will be about stabilizing."*

Government Funding

Another thirteen per cent named government funding directly. The challenges, more specifically, are cuts, freezes, stagnant contracts, and renewal cycles that arrive too late to plan around.

> *"We only have funding guaranteed until March 2026 for both our primary operations, shelter and outreach. We often do not find out until the 11th hour if it is to continue which puts stress on both staff and people relying on the service."*

> *"Getting the ministry of health and housing to the table to discuss health supports needed. Helping funders understand that cuts in funding will equate to reduced services."*

Keeping Up with Inflation

Some named economic conditions such as inflation, utilities, fuel, insurance, and market wage rates that are set outside of their control. Several described the arithmetic plainly: expenses climbing at one rate, while revenue is at another.

> *"Navigating operating costs that are increasing at a significantly faster rate than our revenue streams."*

> *"Staffing can be an issue in a small community. Increases in fuel and ferry costs and fluctuating material prices. Keeping staff wages in line with cost of living can be challenging."*

Space

Facilities and space were named too, which are related to finding premises, affording rent, completing capital projects, or simply having room to grow. It surfaces less often than funding or staffing, but for those who raise it, it is frequently existential rather than incremental (See Section 4. Sustainability: Another Fault Line).

> *"Finding a new home for our organization that is stable and within our means."*
>
> *"Keeping our organization afloat - our mortgage for childcare cannot be covered by childcare fees. There is no or very limited funding to cover it and it impacts all of our programming."*

Leadership Transitions on the Horizon

A small group named leadership, board, or governance concerns. Beyond leadership retirements and succession planning as previously discussed, respondents also touched on the difficulty of recruiting board members.

> *"We are currently planning for succession as our long-term ED is retiring. Despite planning, there are likely to be some challenges, and some financial challenges as additional staff is hired."*
>
> *"Maintaining current service levels. Like many charitable groups, it is hard to find people to sit on our board."*

This collection of challenges describes how non-profits are managing a set of internal and external pressures that reinforce one another, rather than a single obstacle. What the sector anticipates for the year ahead is a widening gap between what communities are asking for and what organizations are resourced to give. This gap has been growing for years. It is time to act on the evidence.

Opportunities

As BC's non-profits respond to growing needs, they will also be actively addressing their organizational sustainability and responding to opportunities.

At the time of surveying, many respondents shared that they are focused on revenue generation, primarily through fundraising and donor development, revenue diversification, or earned income. However, the most common action organizations were already taking to address or improve sustainability was reducing or eliminating services. **For many organizations, sustaining their community-serving mission increasingly means shrinking around it**. This finding deserves serious attention as it speaks to the state of our social infrastructure. Less funding for non-profits directly coincides with fewer services for BC's residents.

Non-profits are also exploring opportunities both stemming from their external environments as well as internally from within their organizations. Four types of opportunities are most common:

1. **Program and service growth or redesign** (22%)
2. **Partnerships and collaboration** (21%)
3. **Fund development** (21%)
4. **Raising organizational profile, awareness and community support** (14%)

Broken down by size, organizations under $1M are mostly looking outward, for partnership, for visibility, for community support. Organizations at $3M and above are anticipating internal opportunities stemming from their systems, service delivery models, and programming. Small and large organizations alike see fund development as an opportunity, at similar rates across all budget sizes.

BC's non-profit sector is actively addressing its sustainability so that it can continue to be a safety net for communities, not only in emergencies but every day. Organizations are cutting where they can and building where they can, often at the same time – demonstrating different forms of resiliency, strategies, and risk-taking.

But resilience without structural support will not improve sustainability. Organizational effort alone will not close the growing gap between communities' needs and non-profits' capacities. Now is a time when all parties - non-profits, government, funders, business, and neighbours - need to join forces to support the non-profit sector to be vibrant and stable. In doing so, we will ensure that communities across BC are strong, healthy, and thriving.

Ending on a Hopeful Note

This year's report presents sector-specific data that is needed more than ever. BC's non-profits are under acute pressure in program and service delivery—more than four in five report that community demand has increased, alongside a deepening of the severity and complexity of needs across our communities. This pressure is extended to organizational finances (most face rising costs, while only a minority saw revenues increase), to human resources (most report unchanged staffing levels despite rising demand), and to the areas of operations and governance.

Our findings this year show that non-profits are adapting to organizational pressures through a variety of strategies, but the gap between demand and organizational capacity continues to exist.

Our respondents reported increased organizational investment in the following areas:

1. **Programs, services, and activities:** relationship-building, outreach, and collaboration; range of program/service offerings
2. **Human resources:** salary and wage levels
3. **Operations and governance:** fund development; IT and digital infrastructure; planning; board governance and recruitment.

These investments, together with the opportunities outlined in the previous section, show a sector that continues to strengthen its operations and frontline support for communities, even while stretched thin and working with resources that cannot fully meet demand.

This year's findings invite a deeper understanding of both the shared experiences and the differences in how BC's non-profits operate and respond to pressure. Many of these findings confirm with data what non-profits already know from their own experience, and provide a shared evidence base from which our sector can collectively chart its path forward. Made possible for the sixth time through a community-driven effort, we hope this report continues to be a resource that sparks conversation, inquiry, and collaboration for the common good that BC's non-profits make possible.

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